

sier structures and spend less money on walls. In my neighborhood, I noticed several S&Ls that resembled greenhouse nurseries, and others that could have been health clubs. Some had fountains and indoor pools.

I was surprised to see that these indoor pools are used as wishing wells by bank customers. A few years ago, when a penny saved was a penny earned, you'd never have found a wishing well in a bank, and certainly not with dimes and quarters on the bottom. That some people prefer to throw away their pocket change on a wish, as opposed to depositing the coins in their savings accounts, is the unfortunate result of inflation. After hours, these coins no doubt are scooped up by the tellers, to add to the banks' overall profits.

We might as well face the fact that small change is only valuable in large quantities, which leads me to my Third Useful Tip:

A penny saved is a penny earned, but so what?

At the old banks, the new banks, and most of the S&Ls I visited, I found long lines at the tellers' windows. The lines seem to grow in direct proportion to the amount of interest that customers received on their deposits. After an informal survey, I concluded that the more interest a person gets for his or her savings, the longer he or she has to wait to get it. Also, eight out of ten tellers' windows in each of the institutions I visited were always tellerless. These seemed to serve as fronts, giving false hope to the customers forced to stand for hours at the occupied windows.

Banks and S&Ls change owners so frequently it's hard to keep up with the names. According to sources in Washington, there have been 670 bank mergers and more than 200 savings-and-loan mergers in the last two years alone. In my own neighborhood, First Nationwide Savings was once known as Washington Savings, Carteret Savings absorbed Amerifirst, Citicorp Savings used to be Biscayne Federal, Centrust was lately called Dade Savings, and Sun Bank was spun out of Flagship, which itself was spun out of United National.

Though we may be a transient population, I'd bet that the av-